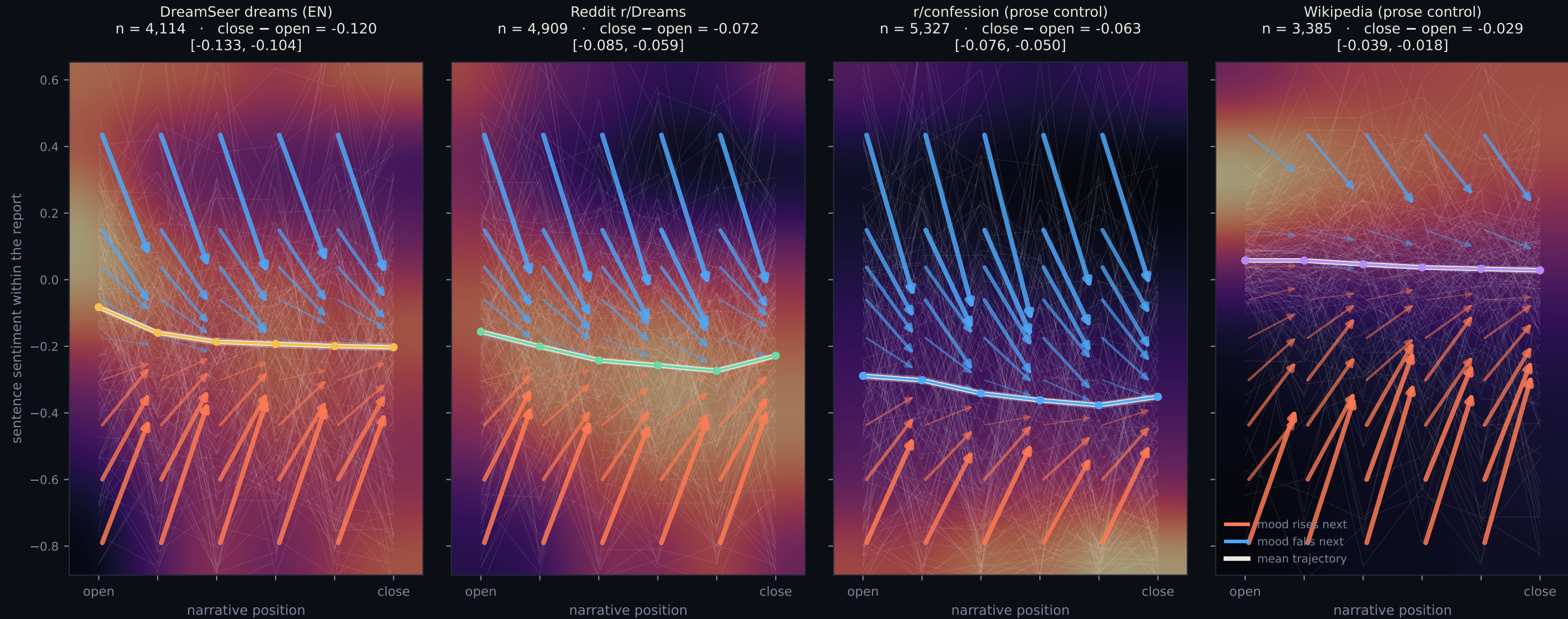


The phase portrait of a narrative: where mood drifts next, given where you are in the story



Every document is cut into six narrative stages and its stage mood binned on a common scale pooled across all four corpora. Arrows are the mean next-stage change for documents currently at that stage and mood level (warm = rises, cool = falls); cells holding fewer than 20 documents or 5 distinct contributors are left empty. Background heat is the share of documents at each level within a stage, faint white threads are 140 individual trajectories, and the bright line is the mean with a 400-draw report-level bootstrap band. All four corpora drift down — the descent is not dreaming's property — and DreamSeer falls furthest; r/Dreams and r/confession are not separated by these intervals. The arrows flip sign with height because a stage scored from a handful of sentences regresses toward the mean; what distinguishes the corpora is where that balance point sits and how fast the mean line falls, not the fan itself. Report-level resampling here, not the contributor-clustered inference behind the published arrow estimates.